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# Top NFL Narratives: True or False?

SAM BROTT // AUG 5, 2024



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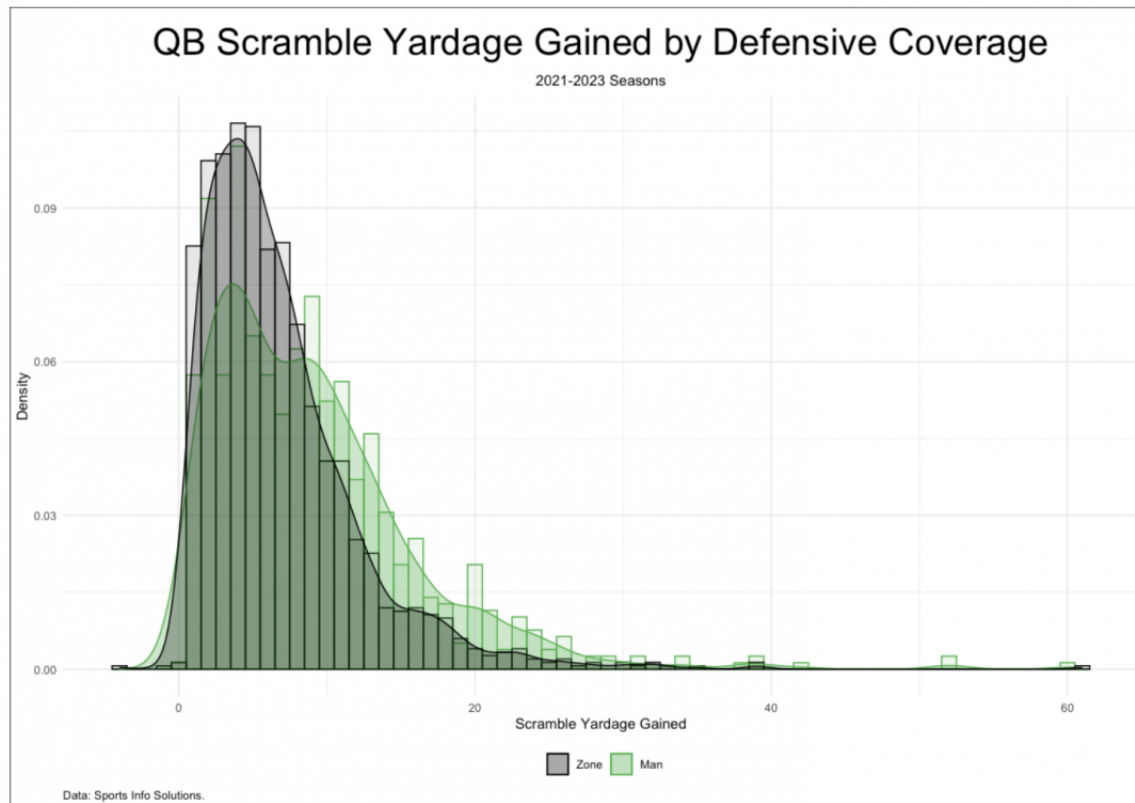
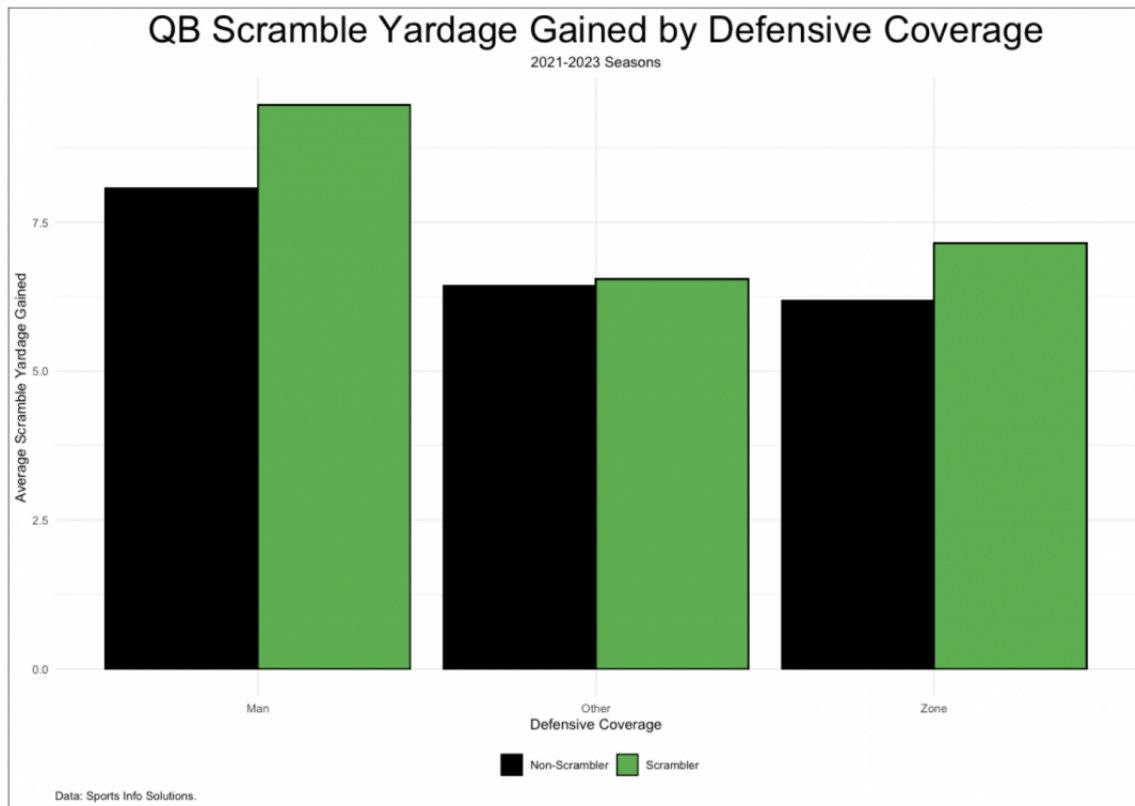
A lot of NFL fans and fantasy players are certain. They're sure that rookie QBs target TEs more often, and rushing QBs throw to RBs less, and fast WRs perform better on turf.

The ETR data science team decided to put these narratives to the test. We used historical results to compare to expectations.

### **NARRATIVE 1: Mobile QBs score better against man defenses**

**Premise:** When defenders are in zone defense, they are able to focus on reading the quarterback. On the other hand, defenders are more likely to have their backs turned to the quarterback when playing man defense. As a result, quarterbacks are more likely to have better scrambling efficiency against man defenses.

**Analysis:** We compared the average scramble yardage gained by defensive scheme for both quarterbacks that do scramble regularly and those who do not. We also reviewed the distribution of all quarterback scrambles from the 2021-2023 seasons against both man and zone defenses.



**Takeaway: TRUE**

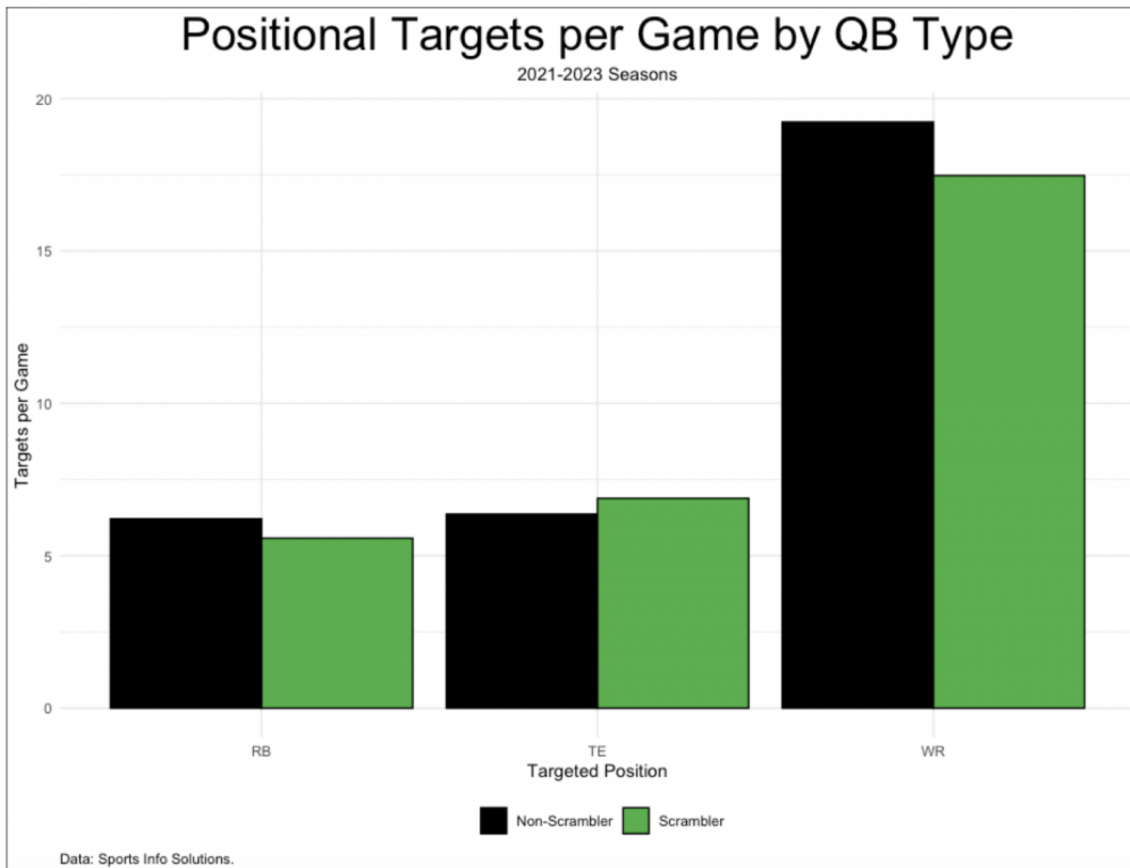
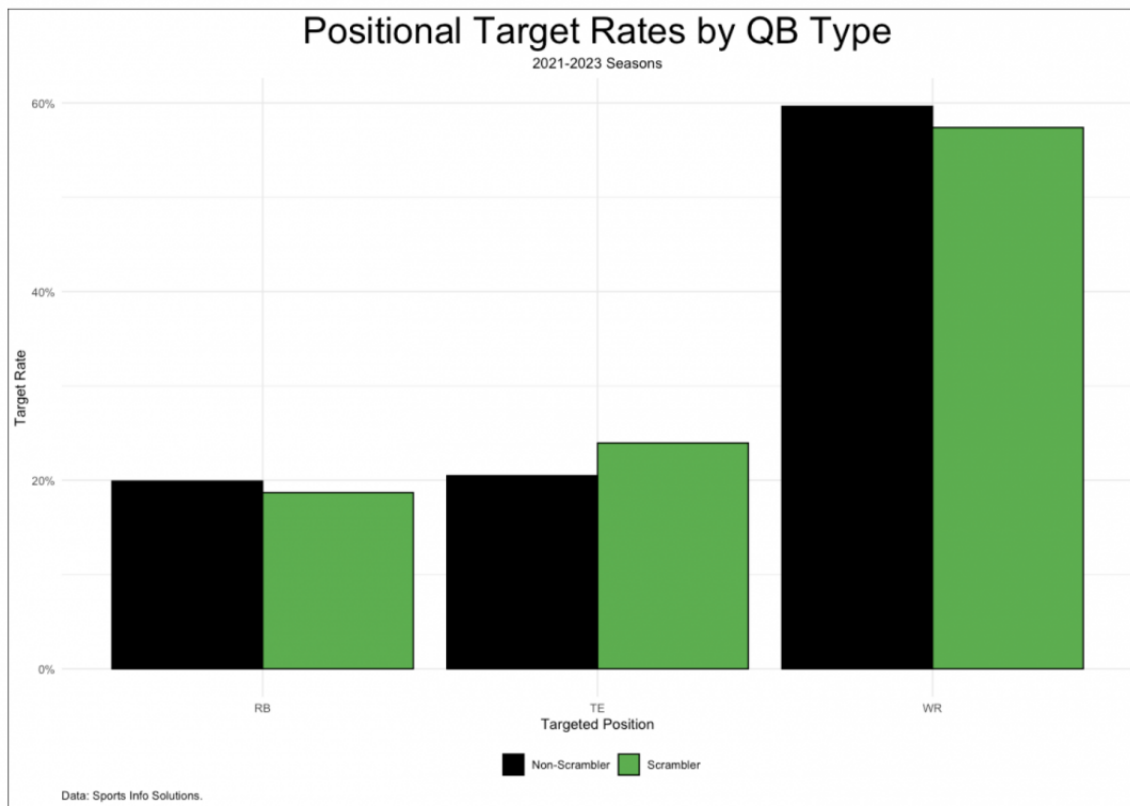
The evidence suggests that quarterbacks have more scrambling success against man defenses. This is true for both quarterbacks that scramble regularly and those who do not. It is worth noting that most scrambles have historically only gone for a handful of yards gained. However, the majority of scrambles that have gained 10 or more yards have come against man defenses, and these are the tail outcomes that we care about most in fantasy. If we can regularly and accurately predict how often defenses will play man versus zone, then we can gain an edge in predicting the likelihood of a quarterback's scrambling success.

**NARRATIVE 2: Mobile QBs throw to RBs at a lower rate**

**Premise:** Quarterbacks who scramble often are less likely to check down to their running backs because they are content to scramble instead.

**Analysis:** First, we compared the total positional target rates for both quarterbacks that do scramble regularly and those who do not. Then, we also compared the positional targets per game for each quarterback type.





**Takeaway: TRUE**

The evidence supports the narrative that scrambling quarterbacks throw to running backs less often than non-scramblers do, but it may not be a meaningful difference. While there is a slight difference in the running back target rates for the two quarterback groups, it is only a ~1% difference. Looking at raw targets per game, scrambling quarterbacks target running backs only ~0.6 fewer times per game than non-scramblers. Overall, the evidence is consistent but also weak and noisy. One example of this noise is that the magnitude of the results is particularly sensitive to the exact thresholds we use to define scramblers versus non-scramblers.

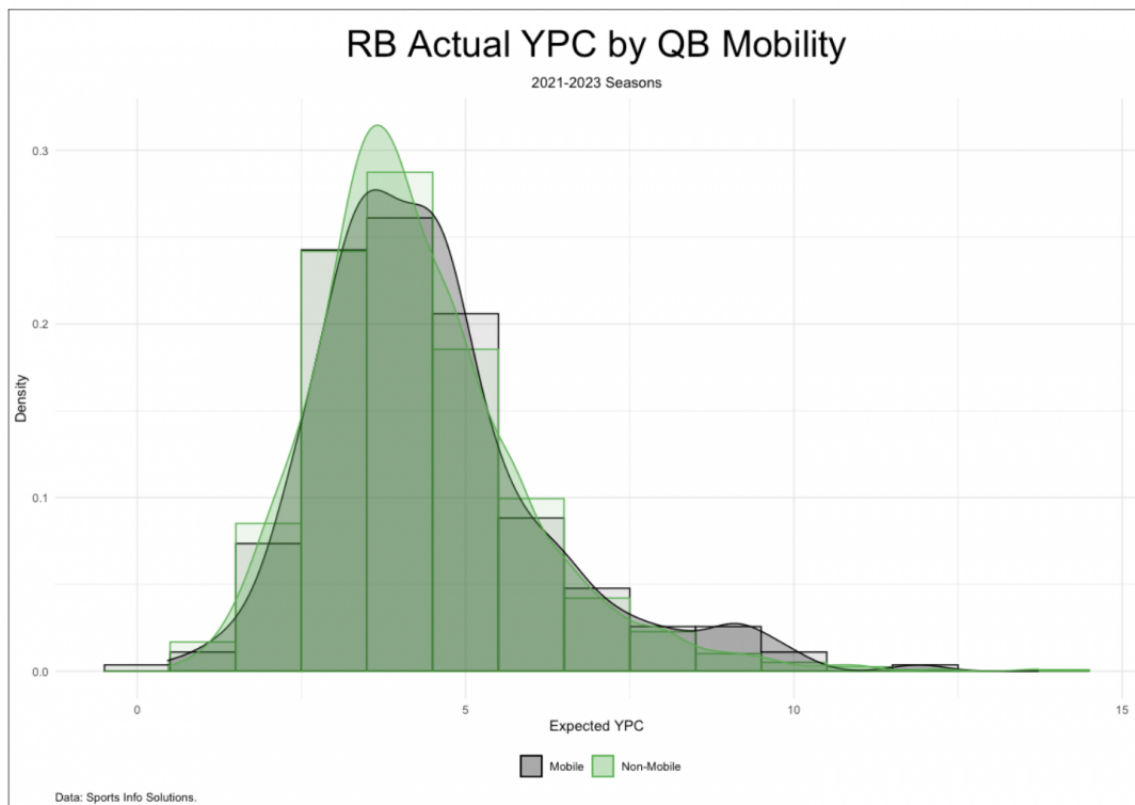
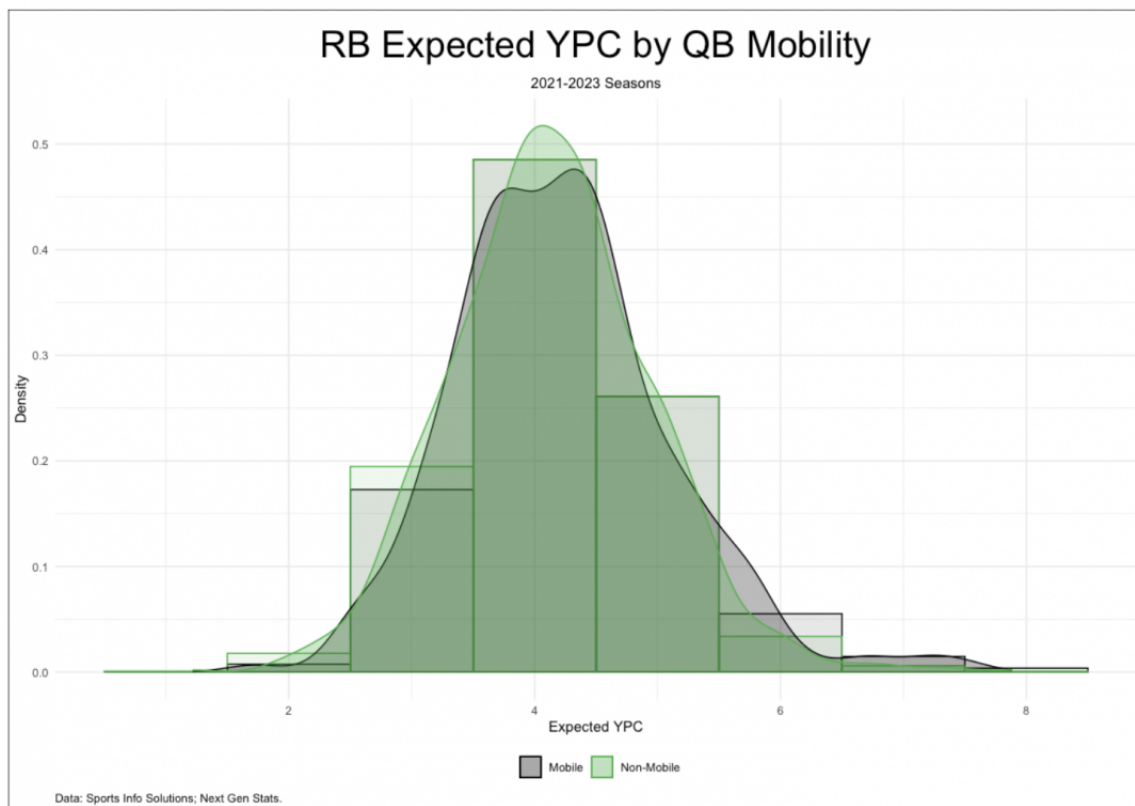
The noisy nature of these results is also highlighted in the notable finding that scrambling quarterbacks have provided more opportunities for tight ends. Here, it is important to recognize that some of the quarterbacks who have scrambled the most over the past three seasons have been tied to teams with an elite tight end or a weaker wide receiver corps (e.g., **Justin Fields**).

**NARRATIVE 3: Mobile QBs provide better rushing opportunities for their RBs**

**Premise:** Running backs will be more efficient when playing with quarterbacks who see significant designed rush shares because opposing defenses must respect the threat of the quarterback's mobility.

**Analysis:** We compared the running backs' expected yards per carry for both quarterbacks that do see regular designed rushes and those who do not. We also analyzed the same comparison using actual yards per carry.





**Takeaway: TRUE**

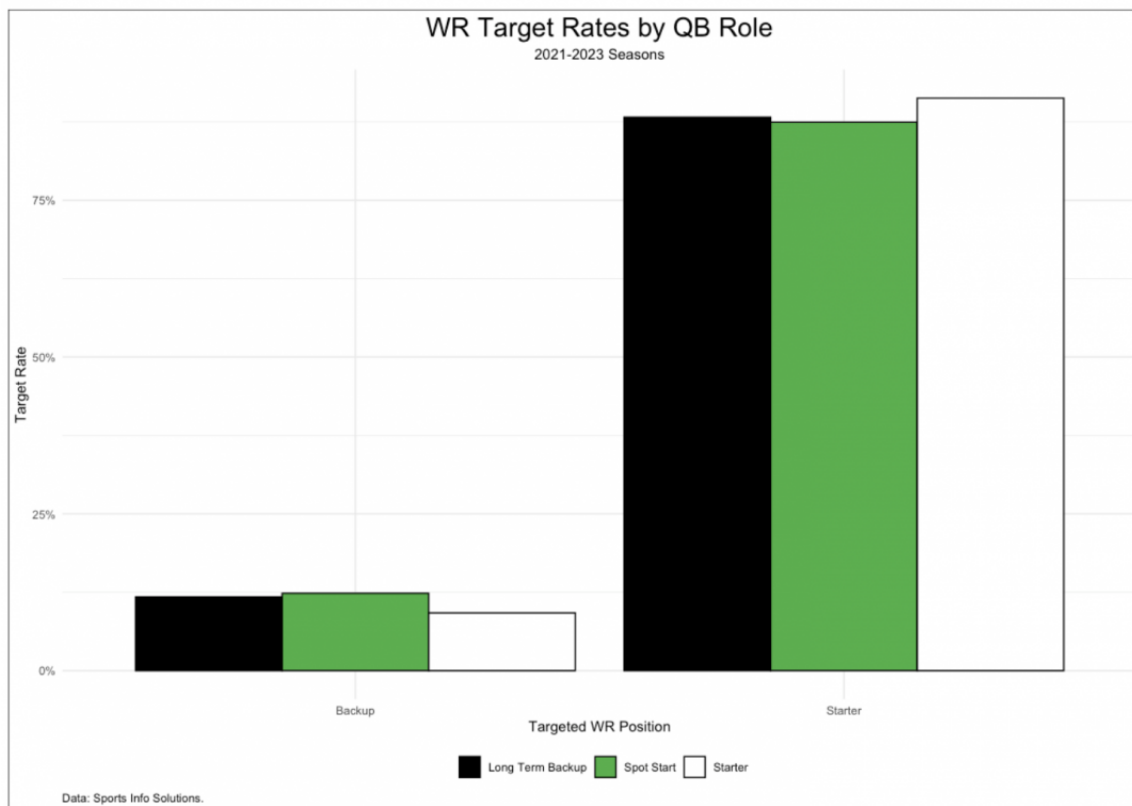
The data indicates that running backs do benefit from playing with mobile quarterbacks, but the evidence is not overwhelming. When looking at Next Gen Stats, the advantage of playing with a mobile quarterback was roughly only 0.1 expected yards per carry on average. This advantage jumps slightly to 0.2 when using actual yards per carry. But perhaps more interesting is reviewing the full distribution of weekly outcomes by quarterback type. As shown in the charts above, running backs have seen slightly more right tail outcomes when playing with mobile quarterbacks. Put another way, most running back carries will go for only a few yards, but playing with a mobile quarterback increases the odds that a running back's carry will be a home run. Once again, these are the tail outcomes that we should look for and can win us weeks in fantasy football. We should be careful to not overweight this narrative, but it may be useful as a ceiling tiebreaker in our weekly decisions.

**NARRATIVE 4: Backup QBs are more likely to throw to backup WRs**

**Premise:** Quarterbacks who were not the starter from Day 1 are more likely to have worked with backup wide receivers in the preseason and weekly practices. As a result, backup quarterbacks are more likely to develop a connection with and target backup wide receivers when they have opportunities to play in the regular season.

**Analysis:** We compared average wide receiver target rates by quarterback roles. We removed Weeks 17 and 18 from this analysis to avoid games in which multiple starters did not play.





**Takeaway:** TRUE

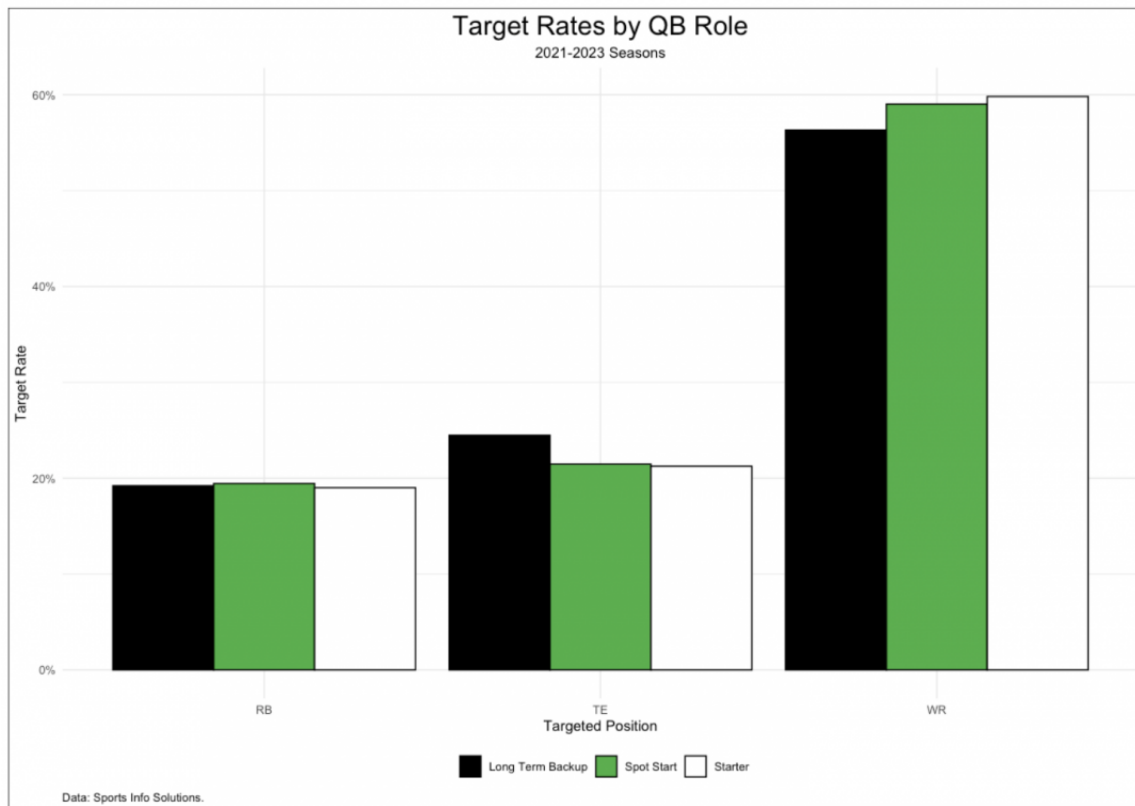
In the 2021-2023 seasons, backup quarterbacks targeted backup WRs approximately 2-3% more often than starting quarterbacks did. This difference is even larger when including Weeks 17 and 18, as expected. While a differential of 2-3% may only yield one additional target per game, these small edges can add up over time. Additionally, these rates may be even more exaggerated when zooming in on specific backup quarterback-receiver duos.

#### **NARRATIVE 5: Backup QBs throw to TEs more often**

**Premise:** Backup quarterbacks are more likely to play it safe with more dependable targets and are therefore also more likely to throw to tight ends than starters are.

**Analysis:** We compared average positional target rates by quarterback roles

from the 2021-2023 seasons.



**Takeaway: FALSE**

As shown in the chart above, quarterbacks in spot starts targeted tight ends at roughly an identical rate to starting quarterbacks. Long-term backups targeted tight ends 3% more often than either of the other quarterback groups, but we found no explanation for why long-term backups would target tight ends more often than short-term backups. We find it difficult to consider this narrative to be true given this discrepancy between the long-term backups and the spot starters. This is a good reminder that even over the course of three full seasons, we generally deal with small sample sizes for NFL analysis and need to be cautious in assuming causation.

## **NARRATIVE 6: Offenses are more likely to exceed fantasy expectations in dome games**

**Premise:** Because domes provide controlled environments and are free of variable weather, teams are more likely to be able to execute their offenses according to plan.

**Analysis:** We compared a variety of key macro stats between dome and outdoor environments to measure the historical impact of dome environments on each stat.

In dome games, relative to outdoor games, we see that:

- Teams score 13% *more* TDs
- Teams run roughly the *same* number of total plays and passing plays (but slightly more running plays)
- Quarterbacks have 22% *fewer* designed rushes and 12% *fewer* scrambles
- Running backs receive 4% *fewer* targets and 18% fewer receiving TDs
- Wide receivers and tight ends record 10% and 12% *more* receiving yards, respectively
- Wide receivers and tight ends score 22% and 33% *more* receiving touchdowns, respectively
- Quarterbacks score 12% *more* DraftKings fantasy points
- Running backs, wide receivers, and tight ends score 6% *more* DraftKings fantasy points
- D/STs score 15% *fewer* DraftKings fantasy points



**Takeaway: TRUE**

The historical data confirms the narrative that dome environments affect macro game outcomes. Domes affect passing games more than the run game, as quarterbacks are more efficient (and less likely to scramble/check down to running backs). We should consider whether our players are playing in dome settings for all positions, but especially for those involved in the passing game. However, be careful not to double-count these effects, as most projections, including ETR's, already account for dome effects to some degree.

**NARRATIVE 7: Multiple high-ADP skill players from the same offense cannot all exceed ADP**

**Premise:** Because running backs, wide receivers, and tight ends typically need high volumes and large touchdown totals to pay off a high ADP, it's unlikely that multiple skill players from the same offense can simultaneously exceed their ADPs.

**Analysis:** We reviewed all instances of a single team having two or more skill players with an ADP of 36 or higher in PPR fantasy drafts from 2015-2023. In these scenarios, 61% of players exceeded expectations.

We also reviewed all instances in which a team had two or more total players (including quarterback) with an ADP of 36 or higher. The success rate is lower overall for this larger group of players at only 56%.

**Takeaway: FALSE**

Historical success rates suggest that we should not be scared of drafting high-ADP skill players regardless of how many "mouths to feed" their offenses have. Season-long projection models like ETR's already account

for each player's micro team environments and we don't need to double-count their impacts.

It was interesting to find that high-ADP players with high-ADP teammates have failed expectations more often when the team's quarterback is one of those teammates drafted in the top 36 spots. This is mostly due to the fragility that's present when an entire offense is predicated on the success of its star quarterback. For example, when **Andrew Luck** was injured in 2015, or **Aaron Rodgers** in 2017, it was much more difficult for their high-ADP teammates to provide value. This is a good reminder of why, even though we want to draft quarterback stacks in best ball tournament formats like Best Ball Mania, it is an unnecessary risk to take on in most season-long fantasy formats.

#### **NARRATIVE 8: QB-WR duos that were college teammates are more likely to succeed (The #ShowerNarrative)**

**Premise:** An Adam Levitan classic. When quarterback-receiver duos who were also teammates (read: showered together) in college, they are more likely to have developed an unbreakable bond during their formative years and therefore the quarterback is more likely to target that receiver more often than another quarterback would.

**Analysis:** We compared the targets per route run (TPRR) for receivers who fit the shower narrative and also played with at least one other quarterback in his career over the 2021-2023 NFL seasons.

Four receivers had a notably *higher* TPRR when playing with their former college teammate:

1. **Jaylen Waddle** (with **Tua Tagovailoa**)
2. **Damien Harris** (with **Mac Jones**)



3. **Robbie Chosen**, formerly **Robby Anderson** (with **P.J. Walker**)

4. **Albert Okwuegbunam** (with **Drew Lock**)

Two receivers had a notably *lower* TPRR when playing with their former college teammate:

1. **DeVonta Smith** (with **Jalen Hurts**)

2. **Travis Etienne** (with **Trevor Lawrence**)

Five receivers had roughly the *same* TPRR when playing with their former college teammate:

1. **Davante Adams** (with **Derek Carr**)

2. **Ja'Marr Chase** (with **Joe Burrow**)

3. **Marquise Brown** (with **Kyler Murray**)

4. **James Washington** (with **Mason Rudolph**)

5. **Dyami Brown** (with **Sam Howell**)

### **Takeaway: CASE-BY-CASE BASIS**

This is a fun narrative to make jokes about and might actually be true for some specific teammates. For example, Waddle had a notable drop in TPRR when Tagovailoa wasn't playing. However, the historical data suggests that this narrative is very rarely predictive and making broad assumptions based on this narrative alone will certainly lead us into trouble.



## **NARRATIVE 9: Freak athletes are more likely to produce outlier results (The PSM Narrative)**

**Premise:** Another Adam Levitan specialty. Players who are freak athletes (also known as players “popping in the PSM”) are just so amazing that they cannot possibly fail to exceed expectations in fantasy football.

**Analysis:** We formally developed and quantified a rigorous PSM for each of the four main fantasy football positions: quarterback, running back, wide receiver, and tight end. We then assigned a PSM score to each player from the 2021-2023 seasons and ranked each player within his position and season. Finally, we compared each player’s PSM score to the difference between our projections and the actual fantasy points scored on a weekly basis for every player.

There was a very weak correlation between a player’s PSM score and their ability to consistently exceed fantasy projections. However, we found one very clear trend: Players who were ranked No. 1 in the PSM in a season for their position *nearly always* met or exceeded ETR’s weekly base projections for the player on average across the season. This list of players includes:

- **Josh Allen**, all seasons 2021-2023
- **Derrick Henry**, all seasons 2021-2023
- **DK Metcalf**, all seasons 2021-2023
- **George Kittle**, all seasons 2021-2023

**Takeaway:** MAYBE TRUE

It’s a tough stretch to consider the PSM narrative to be true. However, it may simply be another way to acknowledge that although these freak athletes are no more likely to exceed their base projections in any given week, their ceilings are massively high when they do exceed expectations.



These are the prototypes of players who may truly be “better in best ball” and make for strong targets in DFS tournaments due to their abilities to reach slate-breaking upsides.

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[Cincinnati Bengals, Ja'Marr Chase, Joe Burrow, NFL Draft Kit Pro](#)



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